StoryCast

Research, Information Architecture & Design Plan

A three-page accessible storytelling microsite concept

Purpose: showcase personal audio and video stories in a calm, editorial interface that supports different ways of consuming media. This document is a planning draft. It does not claim that user interviews or usability tests have already been conducted.

Project principles

1. People before interface — make the story the focus.
2. Access from the beginning — provide captions, transcripts, keyboard support, and readable layouts.
3. Clarity over novelty — use familiar navigation, descriptive labels, and consistent page structure.
4. Responsive by design — content should adapt to narrow screens and narrow components.

1. Information architecture

Primary navigation is kept to three destinations: Discover (home), Featured story (detail), and About & access. The story detail page is reachable from every featured card. The footer repeats important destinations so visitors do not need to return to the top of a page.

StoryCast Global header / footer
■ Discover — index.html
■ Featured story — story/story.html
■ About & access — about.html

Navigation links: Home → Story detail; Home → About; Story detail → Home / About; About → Home / Story detail. All pages share the same header and footer.

2. Page hierarchy and content

Home: skip link, brand/navigation, editorial hero, featured story cards, accessibility statement, footer.
Story detail: breadcrumbs, story title and summary, artwork with caption, audio player, full text transcript, video player with captions track, story notes, related stories.
About & access: mission, prototype transparency statement, accessibility checklist, design principles, story-submission contact link, footer.

3. Wireframes (low fidelity)

Desktop home: 2-column hero (copy left, illustration right); 3-column story cards; full-width mission/accessibility callout; multi-column footer.
Mobile home: compact header with menu toggle; hero copy then illustration; one-column story cards; stacked footer.
Story detail: centered title and artwork; primary column contains media and transcript; secondary sidebar contains story metadata; related cards below. At narrow widths the sidebar stacks after the story content.
About: large page title and intro; two-column mission/access panel; three principle cards; contact band. At narrow widths all sections stack vertically.

Wireframe link: ADD YOUR FIGMA WIREFRAME SHARE URL HERE

4. High-fidelity visual direction

Palette: deep forest green (#174D46) for primary actions, warm paper (#FAF7F0) for the page background, dark ink (#172B2A) for body text, and amber (#F2A65A) as a restrained highlight. Editorial serif headings contrast with a clear system sans-serif body font. Rounded image panels and generous whitespace give the experience a human, calm tone. Illustration assets are local SVGs so the prototype does not depend on external image requests.

High-fidelity Figma link: ADD YOUR FIGMA MOCKUP SHARE URL HERE

Mockup checklist: create desktop and mobile frames for all three pages; include hover/focus states, mobile navigation expanded/collapsed, media controls, transcript expanded/collapsed, and captions shown. Check the design against the implemented site before submission.

5. Accessibility and responsive implementation

The HTML uses semantic landmarks and a single main heading per page. Keyboard users get a skip link and visible focus indicators. The mobile navigation button exposes aria-expanded and aria-controls; the transcript toggle updates aria-expanded and the hidden state. Native media controls are used, a text transcript is present, and a WebVTT captions track is wired to the video element. Replace the sample VTT with accurate synchronized captions when real media is added.

The CSS uses Grid for page-level layout and story grids, Flexbox for navigation and card internals, and a container query for story-card behavior. Sass tokens and partials organize color, type, spacing, base styles, header, home, about, and story components. Reduced-motion preferences are respected.

6. Validation plan

Before final submission: (1) add actual audio/video; (2) generate accurate captions and check transcript against the final recording; (3) test at 320px, 390px, 768px, 1024px, and wide desktop; (4) navigate every control with keyboard only; (5) test a screen reader; (6) run Lighthouse and axe; (7) verify contrast ratios for all text and controls; (8) conduct short usability tests and document real findings and changes without exposing participants' identities.

7. Research status and limitations

This document records a design rationale and test plan, not completed user research. To make the submission genuinely research-driven, recruit a few representative participants, ask them to find a story, start the media, locate the transcript/captions, and find accessibility information. Record task completion, confusion points, and changes made. Obtain consent and anonymize notes.